

The Forgotten God

—“Alright, children, today I am going to tell you a tale that is a little different.”

Varaz always says things like that, but then, his stories always turn out to be fun.

—“Is it about the Princess and her Knight, Varaz?”

—“Well, Borān, sometimes we have to let the story tell its own story and only then will we know.”

—“Okay.”

He can see the slight disappointment in her eyes. The greater her contentment at the end, ha, ha. But this story. Yeah, there is this one incident in his young life he had forgotten about, until his daddy had reminded him of it. And now he has come to view it as some kind of origin story. His origin as a storyteller. So, he now wants to narrate some version of it, just for his own sanity. And as long it has all the fantastical elements the kids love, they will hang once more onto his lips. Success guaranteed, ha, ha.

WELL, it all started in a far and distant city, a place where the sun always shines, except when it rains. There lives this young man, a boy still. And he likes sitting on the pier of the harbor. Watching the boats that sail by. As dreams that come and go but never materialize. Frustrating. For he has his own dreams. To become a mighty warrior, fighting in the name of Justice and All that is Right. ♣

—“What’s his name, Varaz?”

The inevitable question. Why does his audience never accept the sanctity of a name, only to be revealed to the initiate! Because he just made that up, ha, ha.

—“*Alā*, let’s just call him the Heir of Hayk, giving him the privacy he deserves.”

He doubts that the children would know that Hayk was the forefather of all Armenians, but the *Bāmbishn* surely knows. There is no way to hide such things from her.

AND so, the boy, he sighs and languishes. For although his father has told him how to become a valiant warrior, it’s not the route he wants to take. He does not want to

enlist in the Emperor's army, to be sent to fight the evil Avar all the way in those cold, northern lands. And the Avar, they say, are both avaricious and voracious and that's why they are called Avar. And they also say, if the Avar don't chop off your head, frost will bite off your hands and feet. So, no, not the way he imagines himself fighting for Justice and All that is Right. So, he sighs and languishes. Envy the birds in the sky. Not bound by human conventions. Letting out their cry just for the joy of the flight. In the warm sunlight—at least, when it doesn't rain. But birds do pay attention. And so, as he sighs and languishes, a dove comes sit next to him. ~"Drōd [Hello]." The boy looks puzzled at the bird. You don't see a speaking bird every day. In fact, he never heard of anyone seeing a speaking bird—even when it rains. But he is a polite boy, so he replies

~"Drōd."

~"We doves have a saying: *as above, so below*. And that's why we constantly fly up and down—even if it rains. And also, *wherever there is a will, there's a second way*."

~"A second way?"

~"An alternative. Like, tomorrow. The sun will shine... or ... it will rain. See, a second way." Doves probably always speak in riddles, he thinks to himself. That's why the Greek call them *peristerá*, although why, is a riddle in itself. Children, our boy is getting utterly confused. 🐦

Yeah, she has been so confused about that too. So, she turns to Siavash.

—"Siavash, is your mommy the dove?"

Everyone calls his mommy Peristerá [dove], although that is not her name. So much so that she doesn't even know auntie's name. And mom Mariam says that she has earned her moniker and that's why they should call her auntie Peristerá.

—"Ha, ha, no, Borān, doves don't have red hair. My mommy, Peristerá, that is just her nickname. Like mine, Siavash, it means 'black stallion'."

Or like her own, Borān, the 'red' one, on account of her hair. Not something she likes to be pointed out, so she quickly turns back to Varaz.

—"What's the dove trying to say, Varaz."

Well, she gives him this instruction

~“When tonight you lay your tired head on your pillow, imagine underneath is hidden a white feather. And then as you fall asleep, imagine that it is burning.”

~“Why?”

~“So that you can receive your messenger.”

~“Huh?”

~“You know why we never talk to humans? They never want to believe us, for crying out loud.” And with that, the dove flies up and lets out a loud cry. See, children, that’s why doves cry. Even when it rains and the light of the sun turns purple. But the boy thinks, why not give the dove’s cry a try? Why not give the purple rain free rein? And so, that night, he imagines there to be a white feather underneath his pillow and when he is falling asleep, he mumbles,

~“Burn little feather, burn.”

~“*Drōd* [Hello]!” The boy is so startled that he almost wakes up. Next to him on his pillow sits a white bird. But it is not a dove, it is a falcon. No reason not to be polite, and so he replies.

~“*Drōd*! Are you the messenger?”

~“Are you the messengee?”

~“What kind of message is that?”

~“That you should never question white birds!” There we go again with the riddles, the boy thinks. So, he decides to ask the bird a direct question.

~“How can I become a knight, o white one?”

~“By avoiding becoming a knave, o little one.” That’s not very helpful. ♣

—“Varaz, what is a knave?”

—“The opposite of a knight. For knights always speak the truth and knaves always lie.”

—“But we cannot lie, Varaz.”

—“I agree, we all should be knights at heart. Well, except storytellers.”

—“You can lie, Varaz?”

—“Only so that I can ascertain with certainty that at the conclusion of this sentence I will certainly have lied, ha, ha.”

He got startled a bit by the outburst of laughter from the *Bāmbishn*. Her laughing, that was a first! But, it was kind of funny, if you think about it: is he telling the truth? Or is he lying, ha, ha?

—“That makes no sense!”

—“Wait, Shirowe, are you asking whether the answer to this question will be *no*? Well, I wouldn’t know, ha, ha. So, better then to get our senses back and listen to our young boy.”

YOU can sense his frustration.

~“*Pargast*! I don’t want to fight in the army of the Emperor, or for the governor.”

~“The governor, is that still Gennadius?”

~“Yes, him.”

~“Right! *Alā*, you would do well to avoid him. I see your dilemma. Luckily, there is a second way.”

~“So I’ve heard.”

~“It requires the intervention of the Forgotten God.”

~“The Forgotten God. Who is He?”

~“Yeah, I forgot His name. It’s something like the God of Cavalier Contact. Oh, no wait, Godhead of Contractual Cavalry. Uhm no, that’s not it either. . . , well, as I said, the Forgotten God,” he looks a little apologetic, “But I still remember where He lives.”

~“Where?”

~“Well, in the Temple of the Forgotten God of the Cavale-sque Contraction, I mean, the Contracting Cabal, the. . . ,” the white falcon shakes it head and then adds forcefully, “obviously.”

~“Obviously?!”

~“And with the proper invocation, He will help you. Just follow the signs.”

~“Signs? Invocation?”

~“Yeah, silly, the white arrows with wings pointing to His Temple, or have you already forgotten? Oooh, a mouse!”

~“But. . . but. . . .” Too late, children. As sudden as the falcon appeared, it disappears again, in his perennial quest for mice. 🐭

He glances at Abrangih. As she has always snuck out by the time he wants

to ask about her past, he has decided to switch things around. Reveal details in his story in such a way that she wants to know more about him. If Varaz cannot climb the mountain, let the mountain come to him, or something like that, ha, ha. And his glance confirms his suspicion, she looks baffled at him for mentioning the white falcon coming in a dream to the boy. If she really is the cousin of his friend Χorra-Χosrow from distant Yemen, then this must all sound very familiar.

—“Varaz, did the boy find the temple?”

But back to the story.

WELL, those winged arrows were surprisingly easy to follow. And so, after a day’s march, he reaches the little town of Tittitattitorum—or something like that—the locals don’t bother much about proper enunciation, as they just tit-for-tattle along. Through the big gate he walks, on the *kardo*... 🏹

—“What cart is that, Varaz?”

—“Oh, ha, ha, *kardo*, that’s what the *Hromāyig* [Roman] call their main street. It always runs from north to south.”

—“Always?”

—“Unless you come from the other direction, then it runs from south to north, ha, ha.”

AND there, on the forum of Tittitattitorum, he sees a small basilica. Could that be the Temple of the Forgotten God? But when he asks, the people respond, a little tittletattled

~“Why would anyone forget that that’s the Temple of Our Lord IESOUS ΧRISTOS? Don’t you see? We even wrote His name in big letters on it.” Right! So, that’s not it then. He turns around. The winged arrow guides him towards a little alley opposite the basilica. And there, it settles down on a big column. That must be it! 🏹

—“There is no such thing as arrows flying around to point the way!”

—“I agree, Shirowe, from most flying arrows one would rather want to flee away, ha, ha. But what matters is, he found the entrance to the Temple.”

Shirowe was of course right, no arrows with wings. But the thing with

wings he had seen at the temple, that was best censored for his young audience. Although, it was quite funny: a phallus with wings! Someone had carved it on one of the columns. He still remembers showing it to daddy, and they had laughed so hard.

WHEN he enters, it is quite dark and the hall is empty. He lights a torch and then sees at the back a round opening, leading to a cave in the rock. As he descends, he can feel a spectral presence surrounding him—it is creepy but also a little alluring. This is the Temple of the Forgotten God, he is sure of it now. And when he is down in the vault, he can make out at the other end a big statue. That must be the deity! He comes closer and sees that the Forgotten God is straddling with one leg a big animal—it's a bull. And he is about to slit the beast's throat. Should he try to stop it? Or should he help? He has heard all these fantastic tales about pagan rites in which they sacrifice in all kind of manners. He is just hoping that it is not him who is going to be the slaughtered lamb. Perhaps he should go back? But what about his chivalric aspirations then? So, he decides, he should invoke the God.

~“O Deity of the Carnavalesque Contraptions with Convalescent Contractions...,” *pargast*, he forgot the name of the deity—that's perhaps His power—although, the boy, he'd rather be remembered. Hopefully, one day, as a valiant knight, “heareth my plea, fulfilleth my wish, for I want to become Thy servant in the defense of Justice and All that is Right.” But the God remains silent, just staring at our poor supplicant, who starts shivering. It's a little chilly in the cave, but that's not why he is shivering. He looks up and sees the faces of the Moon and the Sun, staring at him without saying anything. And then he notices that there are also a serpent and a scorpion crawling on the statue. . . 🐍

—“Oh no, Varaz, are they going to bite him?”

WELL, luckily, they too are carved in stone, and so, they remain as immobile as the God Himself. Perhaps, children, it is for the best that everything remains petrified. And therefore, so does the boy. But in spite of his fear, he has to

try one more time. He remembers the white falcon telling him to perform the proper ritual. Should he fetch a bull and kill it himself. Without a knife? And where is he going to find a bull willing to come to its own slaughter? He throws himself on the floor and implores

~“O God Whose name shall not be mentioned, I beseech Thee, maketh me Thy servant. I will do whatever it takes.” And then, all of a sudden, a loud voice, in a commanding tone!

~“Do not move or you will die!!” Oh, no, has he blasphemed? 🐘

—“Blast a meme?”

—“Ha, ha, no. Blaspheme means saying the wrong things about a deity, to speak irreverently about Him.”

SO, the boy thinks: that’s the end of me! And then he hears the crack of a whip and he braces himself...—they all look fearful at him. As he felt that time—and then... snap. 🐘

He waits to get them all squirm on their cushion.

—“Varaz, did it...”

IT missed! And now the voice says ~“Phfew, that was close, boy. Come here, it’s not safe there.” The boy looks surprised at the man who has entered the cave. He puts his whip away and holds out his hand to help him up.

~“What?”

~“A scorpion! It was crawling on your back while you were laying down there. Why on earth would you lay on that dirty floor. It’s full with spiders and bugs and... well, scorpions.”

~“I...I...wanted to ask for... you know, from the Forgotten God, ..., to make Him my servant,” he is still shaking over all his body, “I mean, ..., to make Me his servant... to make me His servant in the fight for Justice and All that is Right.”

~“Forgotten God? Why would you call Him that way. Don’t you see, he is the Sacrificer of the Bull. The Sacred Sacrificer of the Scared Bull.”

~“Scared bull?”

~“Well, wouldn’t you be if they hold a knife to your throat?”

~“I guess. But why does He do this?”

~“So, that the cow’s milk would bring forth the keys to unlock the east from the west. And from the bull’s semen would sprout all the animals and plants on earth. See, ears of wheat are already growing out of his tail and the blood coming from his wound is turning into grapes.” Apart from these transformative transgender transfigurations mystifying him, the boy gets a little worried. Perhaps he is making his supplication to the wrong deity? And then, who is this mysterious man who knows the Forgotten God?

~“Dear Sire, you saved my life. Can I ask who you are?”

And then the man reveals his identity. Children, you’re never going to believe this! 🐘

—“Who, Varaz, who is he?”

Well, let him introduce himself

~“My name is Sailing-Seven-Seas-Searching-Solemn-Secrets-Seeking-Solacing-Sacraments-Striving-Sacred-Salvation,” the boy tries to repeat his name, but it becomes a lot of silly sounding sss’s, so the man says, “but you can just call me Captain.” See, children, it is the Captain! 🐘

—“Yay! The Captain! He saved the boy,” she has a little suspicion, “and the boy, is he then the. . .”

—“*Alā*, *Borān*, remember what I told you about the telling of the story telling its own story?”

Let’s wait and find out.

~“Captain? How did you get here?”

~“Well, by ship, obviously.”

~“But. . . but. . . , I didn’t see any sea here other than the episcopal see across the street with the big C of our Lord CHRIST on top.”

~“Oh, not that kind of ship. I came on a Desert Ship!”

~“A deserted ship?”

~“No, silly, a camel! Haven’t you heard of this noble beast that can carry more water than the ocean herself.”

~“Oh, right, ha, ha. I had forgotten about those two-humped beasts of burden.”

~“Wait, how many humps is it supposed to have? Mine only had one! Perhaps that’s why the ride was so bumpy. But be that it as it may, I am curious, boy, what exactly made you come worship the Sacrificer of the Bull in this sacred scary place. Aren’t you supposed to be fearing some other deity.” See, children, the boy is a *Tarsāg* [Christian] and we call them that way because they fear (*tarsag*) God. Well, some say, it’s because those that do not believe in ΧΡΙΣΤΟΣ should fear His wrath. But let’s not get into theological debates. Our own hero-in-spe has his own doctrinal doubts.

~“I came, honorable Captain, to submit myself to the God so that he would knight me into his order, to fight for Justice and All that is Right. But I think I got the wrong deity.”

~“Wrong deity? Are you kidding me? This is the One you want. He is the One Who will smite the odious oath-breaker, the callous contract-breaker. He will carry off the vigor of their arms, the strength of their feet, the light of their ears, the hearing of their ears.¹ He is the Righter of wrongs, the Wrangler of the unrighteous, the Abolisher of Avimithra the Antichrist. His Circle of Justice circumfers the Disk of the Sun, His Chariot of Chivalry circumnavigates the Righteous Realms. He is the Father of the Brotherhood into which you seek membership.”

~“And how then shall I do this, Captain. He doesn’t answer my prayers?”

~“You have to worship him with speech of correctly uttered words.²”

~“Do you know the right words, Captain.”

~“It has been a while, my young friend, so let me think.” Children, do you think the Captain will remember? 🐘

—“He has to, Varaz, otherwise the boy will never become a knight!”

Let’s see how much he still remembers from the sacred scriptures.

¹Hymn to Mithra, 23.

²Hymn to Mithra, 6.

~“Alright, boy, say after me. But for it to ring true, you must use your own words.” And so their hallowed chant echoes in the hollow sanctum.

~“O Hero of the Bull...,”

“...O Champion of the Cow”

~“supernatural...,”

“...and metaphysical”

~“foremost...,”

“...and last but not least”

~“merciful...,”

“...and full of clemency”

~“measureless...,”

“...and without bound”

~“upon high...,”

“...dwelling in the sky”

~“mightily strong warrior³...,”

“...strongly mighty charioteer.”

Nothing happens though! And then the Captain realizes.

~“Oh, we forgot something. You should always start with invoking Him as:”

~“O Lord of the Wide Pastures...,”

³Hymn to Mithra, 140.

“...O Grassland Magnate!”

And then a loud voice booms around the vault, making them both cringe. It comes from the statue! Lightning-bolts are flashing, the earth is shaking and there appears, descending from the vault of the cave, as water springing forth from rock, the God Himself, immensely great, bright in appearance, youthful, golden-haired, wearing a white tunic and golden crown and trousers, and holding now in his right hand, the golden shoulder of the Bull.⁴

~“Who has mentioned my name in his prayer? Are you men who own Truth? Should I come forward to you for the duration of limited time, interrupting My own radiant immortal life?⁵” The boy now wonders how wise it had been to interrupt the immortality of a radiant being, but the Captain shoves him forward, indicating with his head that he should speak up.

~“O Slayer of Bull, I worship Thee and ask Thee to take me as Thou servant.”

~“A Contractual Knight of Righteous Justice you want to become? Let Me ask. Are you adept at theurgy? Can you conjure the evocation of the four elements?” The boy has no clue and so he looks desperately at the Captain, who whispers—hoping that the God won’t hear him—but He has thousand ears, so, good luck with that.

~“I’ll tell you what to do.” So, he scrapes all his courage together and replies.

~“O Hero of the Cow, as Thou commands, I will summon the four elements.”

~“Air!” He looks at the Captain who makes a soft humming sound. The boy goes with his eyes like ‘what?’, so the Captain whispers—pointlessly if you ask me

~“Hum m!”

~“Hum hum?”

~“Hum the m-sound!”

⁴Mithras Liturgy, 695-700.

⁵Hymn to Mithra, 55.

~“Like hmm?”

~“Yeah, but without the h!” And so the boy chants

~“MMM!” It seems to please the God, for he now asks.

~“Fire!” After a little hence-and-forth with the Captain, he goes

~“EY EYA EYE!”

~“Water...,”

“...OOO AAA EEE”

~“Earth...,”

“...YE YO YE.”

And then the Captain tells him to add

~“This is my complete body, I, whose mother is Nvard, who was formed by a noble arm and an incorruptible right hand in a world without light and yet radiant, without soul and yet alive with soul, YEI AYI EYOIE!⁶” Thus the boy invoked and evoked the elements. 🌱

He is pretty sure that Nvard was not the wife of Hayk, the forefather of all Armenians, but she definitely was a queen occurring in their myths. So, close enough to becoming the boy’s mother. It would probably lead to a correction of the *Bāmbishn* afterwards. Perhaps she though could tell him the name of the Armenian matriarch.

—“Did it work, Varaz?”

—“O, children, amazing! Simply amazing. Can you guys see it?”

—“What, Varaz, what?”

FROM the flank of the bull pops up a leather-bound book. It just hovers above the floor, a green glow filling the dark dome. Written on it in golden letters, they can read ‘As above, so below’.⁷ That’s the dove’s motto! A sign that he is on the right path, which he hopes, is going to go up.

~“Is this Thou Holy Book, O Lord of Light?”

~“This is the Omniscient Oracle of the Orb. In it, there is

⁶Mithras Liturgy, 485–500.

⁷Emerald tablet, 2.

written the ever-lasting, never-ending story of all the Knights that fight for Justice and All that is Right. You wish to add your name to this book?" His wish is going to come true, children. He can barely believe it! So he vigorously nods his head. But deities like to hear words of worship, so he quickly adds.

~"Oh, yes, O Magnificent Magnate of Mildew Meadows, O Strong One, O Stronger One, O Strongest One."

~"Very well then. Pick a page!" The boy wants to open the book, but the Captain pulls him back, just in time. Children, you cannot just touch the Oracle of the Orb. Its omnipotence obliterates the obnoxious and obfuscates the audacious. Besides, he wouldn't be able to read the inside for it is written in green letters on green parchment. 🐉

—"Why, Varaz?"

—"For not everything is black and white."

—"That is so dumb. Who would then be able to read it?"

—"The colorblind? I don't know, Shirowe. What do we know about the affairs of the Gods?"

BUT like you, the boy is confused
~"But the God said to pick a page . . ." The Captain now points to two young men standing next to the statue. They had appeared together with the book, but the boy had been so mesmerized by the marvelous mirage, that he had not noticed them. And now he realizes, when the God said pages, he meant these young men. One of them is standing with a torch pointing upwards. And the other—his twin brother—looking in all aspects exactly the same as his brother, except he's pointing his torch downwards. What use is that? So, he picks the one with the upwards torch, presumably the smarter one.

~"Very well, young supplicant, you chose the cautic page named Srshrshn. Personally, I'd prefer sunset over sunrise, but to each its own." The boy doesn't understand that last bit, but decides to ignore it. Instead he asks

~"O Lord of the Bovine, what name is his?"

~"Oh, Srshrshn, he is from the race of the Abjad. They all

have such non-sounding names. The other page, his name is Rshnsrsh. But you chose Srshrshn, and he will now assist you. Speak Srshrshn."

~"I, Th'rth'rth'n, will ath'th'ith't."

~"Atheist? No, no, I need a believer to help me."

~"You mith'underth'tand, th'upplcant, I am a loyal acolyte of my Lord: I th'all ath'th'ith't you in your th'earch." The boy looks at he Captain, who whispers back

~"I think he has a lisp."

~"That'th not a nith'e thing to th'ay, Captain Th'ailing-Th'even-Th'eath-Th'earching-Th'olemn-Th'ecretth-Th'eeeking-Th'olacing-Th'acramentth-Th'triving-Th'acred-Th'alvation! I juth't loth't my front tooth."

~"Your front toes?" The page Srshrshn shows the gap between his teeth. 🦷

Doing the lisp is harder than he expected—who knew there are so many s-sounds—but it cracks up its audience. He just has to make sure that they do not get lost in the meaning of the words.

Alright, children, I think we are going to make our boy into a man. *Alā*, as long as he gets what the page is saying. The page now takes the book that is still hovering and starts reading from it—see, immortals have excellent eyesight. Even their pages.

~"The th'upplcant th'all path through three gradeth. Which are the three gradeth?"

~"Great, greater, greatest?"

~"No, I th'aid grade! And thoth'e are Raven, Bridegroom and Mileth."

~"Millet?"

~"No, mileth, that ith Latin for th'oldier."

~"Oh, *miles*. Yes, I want to become *miles*."

~"One th'tep at the time, young th'upplcant. One th'tep at the time. The firth't one ith that of Raven. Whith' ith itth th'ign." It takes the boy a little to decode that the page must mean 'sign'. Now, meanwhile, on the floor and walls many pictures have appeared, drawings of swords, helmets, and pikes, but also things like a cup or a bird or weirder things

like two snakes entwined. But a raven, he thinks, that's a bird and so he points to the picture of the bird.

~"This one?"

~"Well, yeth, that'th the raven. But what ith itth th'ign? What planetary conth'tellath'ion?" Next to the picture of the raven is the one with the two snakes, and the Captain whispers in his ear.

~"I think that is what the Romans call a *caduceus* and it is the sign of the God MERCURY, the Planet of Quicksilver." So, the boy replies that it is Mercury and the page, pleased by his answer, continues.

~"Who ith the *Pater* [Father]? The th'uppllicant will th'ay: 'The one who begetth everything.' 'How did you become Raven?' Th'ay: 'By the grath'e of the *Pater*.' 'How will you th'elebrate?' Th'ay: 'Drink and food'.⁸" So, the boy follows the instructions. But when he says drink and food, Srshrshn asks where it is. A little crestfallen, he replies.

~"I did not bring any food or drink." Yeah, children, that was not very smart of our boy. To travel without sustenance. It's like singing without air.

~"What about your *Pater* [Father]?" He didn't bring his daddy either.

~"He is at home."

~"Your th'pirtual *Pater*? Ith he not th'tanding nekth't to you?" The boy looks up at his savior, who has put a hand on his shoulder. Yeah, that'll work. See, children, thus, for the purpose of the ritual, the Captain will become the Father and the boy the Son.

~"Here, son, eat some of this bread," the Captain breaks the loaf he brought with him in two, "as it were like the body of your *Pater*. And drink some of this wine from my cup, as it were like the blood of your *Pater*."

~"Amen!"

~"And let us celebrate your ascension into Raven," and they drink from the cup, "To happiness! To MEHR [MITHRA]!" Srshrshn politely declines a sip—not while on the job, he

⁸Papyrus Berolinensis 21196, recto.

says—, but claps his hands.

~“Now you have become Raven, th’uppliant, now you’re the Cadet of Caduceuth. And the neth’t grade to enter ith Bridegroom.” Srsrshn tells him again what to do and at the end they celebrate with some more bread and wine. Which is getting the boy a little tipsy. But there is one more grade to go, one more step too steep, one more rung to ring. See, I told you, the wine is getting to his head, getting his metaphors all mixed up, ha, ha.

~“Ekth’elent! Now you ath’t ended to the rank of Bridegroom, th’uppliant. You have become the Th’quire of the Ekth’quith’ite,” okay, children, this is a difficult one—even I am not sure what he was trying to say—but my best guess is that the boy has ascended from Cadet of the Caduceus to Squire of the Exquisite. Anyway, it doesn’t matter that much, for he still has to go one step higher, “And the neth’t grade to enter ith Mileth.” And then, some more yadda yadda yadda, and poof, from squire he becomes *miles*. 🐼

—“Yay!”

THE page Srsrshn continues

~“Dear th’uppliant, now that you have become Mileth of the Militant, I cannot further help you. The next th’tep, you’ll have to take not by wordth but by th’word. To become Lion, you muth’t be Lion. And I would alth’o highly recommend to aspire one grade higher, go to Perth’ith onwards.”

~“Perdition?”

~“No. Ath in the country, Perth’ia!” And so, children, our boy-turned-knight-overnight contemplates a visit to Persia. 🐼

See, she was right, the boy, he is the Knight after all. But then where is his prin...

THE Captain congratulates the boy but then cautions him.

~“Do not rest, aspiring knight, until you’re complete. For now you’re only half.”

~“Half?”

~“A raven without a dove, a bridegroom without a bride, a

miles without a princess." So, children, our aspiring knight.

He needs a princess. Where will he find one? ♣

—"Well, Persia is the right place to come. We have some spare ones here." Her brother looks at Āzar, but she looks defiantly back.

—"Ha, ha, Shirowe. Wouldn't we not all want to become Princess and Knight, to roam in stories told forever, written ever-lasting, never-ending, in the Omniscient Oracle of the Ornate Orb."

—"But, Varaz, the Knight needs to find his Princess. Tell us how!"

—"That story, Āzar, will still need to unfold. And we have to patiently wait until the Oracle of the Orb decides for it to be told."

—"But... but... the Captain said that the Knight is not yet complete!"

—"Yeah, Varaz, we have to believe that an immature boy, all of a sudden, with some mere hoodoo-vooodoo, has turned into an able swordsman?"

—"Such is the power of the Forgotten God, Shirowe. Makes you wonder why *pad Yazdān* [by the gods] did people ever forget about Him." After the children have left, the *Bāmbishn* asks him

—"The postulate of syncretism, not unprecedented. Whence its provenance?" Is she asking why he thinks the temple he visited is related to the Persian deity MEHR [MITHRA]. Probably. So he replies.

—"From Lady Gordiyag. I think she got it herself from her storyteller. So, perhaps, it's just stories, Your Majesty."

—"No. Parrwānag, she is no mere storyteller, an astute, analytical mind having inspected a comparable temple," she thinks a little, "A symposium of mythological cognoscenti. Inclusive yourself. And also Lady Wishtiwinin." He is not sure how happy Lady Wishtiwinin would be to see him, as his father was basically responsible for her becoming a widow. But then, *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* Gordiyag didn't hold that against him either. But what an honor, to be considered one of the cognoscenti, one of the illustrious imperial illuminati. The III, ha, ha. That sounds more like his stomach crying for service. After assuring his origins, now his organs needs assuaging, ha, ha. But all joking aside. He would not have been here, if Captain Mehrān had not shown up on the right time back then and had killed that scorpion. Makes you wonder...